

The Basics of Parliamentary Debate

1. What is It?

It is a form of extemporaneous debate where two teams debate a **proposition** (AKA a **resolution** or **motion**) that is announced 20 minutes before the round starts. One team affirms the proposition (is in favor of it) and one team negates the proposition (is against it).

2. What is a proposition or motion in debate?

It is the topic being debated, and there are three types of propositions –

- **Statements of fact** – these resolutions are opinions that are stated as facts. Both teams try to prove that the fact is true or false. How can you tell if a topic is a **fact** topic? Ask yourself if there is a simple “yes” or “no” answer or if they have stated an opinion as a fact.
 - Example: The current president has done more harm than good.
- **Questions of value** – both sides push for their value (principle or standard) as superior to the other side’s value. How can you tell if a topic is a **value** topic? Ask yourself if it asks which of two options is better or if it asks you to place importance on some standard or principle.
 - Example: Using alternative sources of energy is more important than economic considerations.
- **Questions of policy** – the proposition shows that there is a problem in the status quo (the way things are now) and requires a solution/plan/policy to take care of the problem. Often it involves a change in the United States Federal Government, or the USFG. How can you tell if a topic is a policy topic? Does the resolution contain the words, “should” or “would”? Ask yourself if 1) a change is needed for this proposition to happen or 2) if a new system would be needed to make this motion go into effect.
 - Example: The United States should guarantee a free college education for all citizens.

3. The style of Parliamentary Debate.

This debate is more conversational and less confrontational. Wit (humor) in moderation is **encouraged**. Speakers should show more personality and flair. It is also slower paced than some kinds of debate. Even though it is more casual in style, speakers still need good delivery techniques. A poor delivery can wipe out all the good arguments that you are going to be making.

4. Format of Parliamentary

A parliamentary debate round lasts for a total of 40 minutes – 31 minutes for constructive speeches and 9 minutes for rebuttals.

Constructive speeches come first – During these speeches, the teams present their arguments and lay out their cases. All arguments on both sides **MUST** be presented during the constructive speeches. No **NEW** arguments are allowed during rebuttals. There is **NO** prep time between speeches. Each speaker must be up to speak within 20 seconds of the person who spoke before. This is true for both constructive **AND** rebuttal speeches

First Affirmative speech	7 minutes
First Negative speech	8 minutes
Second Affirmative speech	8 minutes
Second Negative speech	8 minutes

Rebuttal speeches come last

Negative rebuttal	4 minutes – <u>Given by the first opposition speaker</u>
Affirmative rebuttal	5 minutes – <u>Given by the first proposition speaker</u>

As you begin debating, the member of your team who is most confident at rebuttals should be the one to speak twice. Therefore, the most confident speaker should be the first affirmation or first negation speaker. Later, you can make strategic changes as you discover each other's strengths and weaknesses.

5. What happens during preparation time?

Once your team learns what the topic for each debate will be, you will have 20 minutes to prepare. During this time, you will sometimes be working by yourself and sometimes you will work with your partner. BOTH partners must work equally hard to get done on time. Just like a married couple, you will learn how you work best together and how you can divide up the jobs you need to get done. You will get better at this the more you debate. At the end of your 20 minutes, you will need to have your general case planned. You will need to know the arguments you will present. In short, you will need to be ready to go into battle with the other team. In chapter 4, you will learn how to effectively use those 20 minutes of time.

6. Asking questions during debate.

Yes, the other team can ask questions of the person who is speaking during constructive speeches – these are called Points of Information, or POIs. You can use POIs to get information you missed or to show a weakness in the speaker's case. If you are the speaker, you can choose to answer a question or not. I always encourage debaters to ask at least one question and to answer at least one question. You will learn more about doing effective POIs in Chapter 11.

7. Debate etiquette.

Here's what to remember: this is a POLITE argument – not a knock-down-drag-out fight. You must always be respectful of the other team. You should never be pushy or talk down to the other team. And remember, you can communicate all kinds of things with non-verbal communication – so be careful to never roll your eyes, laugh, or make faces. That is VERY bad behavior.

You can talk to your partner during the other team's speeches, but it must be done very quietly. You must whisper and you must keep it very brief.

You may hear some knocking -- Students will sometimes knock on their desk if they think their partner made a good point. Also, at the end of a rebuttal speech, you might give a knock on the desk for the other team. But don't go overboard with the knocking – it should be subtly done.

8. Debating at a tournament.

When you go to a tournament, you will debate against teams from other schools. In the actual debate, it will only be your team, the other team, and a judge. There are usually no spectators. Your first tournament will be a little scary, but you will be fine. Your coach will go over all these things with you very carefully before you head off for your first big competition. In the meantime, you need to start learning more about this thing called parliamentary debate!